

BEYOND THE BLOCKBUSTERS

AFTER THE WEIGHT-LOSS DRUG BOOM, AND WITH GENERICS CLOSING IN, BIG PHARMA ARE GEARING UP FOR THE NEXT GAME-CHANGER

BY NEETU CHANDRA SHARMA

| 59

A large, stylized green letter 'W' graphic, serving as a drop cap for the first paragraph.

WHEN DANISH DRUG maker Novo Nordisk A/S started testing higher doses of Semaglutide, an anti-diabetic and anti-obesity medication, in 2024 to extend weight-loss outcomes, its American rival Eli Lilly & Company was pushing an oral obesity treatment through regulators.

Around the same time, Amgen Inc. of the US, still without an approved obesity therapy, trod a different route, backing a long-acting treatment needed to be injected just once every few months to check the disorders.

These moves were not about replacing today's GLP-1 blockbusters like Novo Nordisk's Ozempic and Wegovy or Lilly's Mounjaro, which will go off-patent in the coming months and years after driving record valuations for their

makers. GLP-1 is short for Glucagon-Like Peptide-1, a class of medications mimicking a natural hormone to regulate blood sugar, reduce appetite and promote weight loss.

As competition intensifies in obesity and Type 2 diabetes therapies and the first generation of GLP-1 matures, Big Pharma and its Indian units are moving past the idea of a single, dominant product to replace GLP-1 products. Drug makers are building broader, multi-layered metabolic portfolios that combine oral and injectable therapies, precision-targeting obesity, diabetes and related conditions for the long term.

For India, its disease burden makes the transition both a medical and commercial imperative. Economic Survey 2025-26 cautioned that rising obesity